

Two Pointers

Saturday, May 2, 2026 9:50 AM

Where you use two indices that traverse a data structure.

When to use two pointers:

- Sorted input
- Pairs or subarrays
- Sliding window problems
- Linked lists

Example: given a sorted array and a target, find if there exists any pair of elements, such that their sum is equal to the target.

- 1) Naïve method: time complexity $O(n^2)$ and space $O(1)$. It consists in generating all the possible pairs and check if any of them add up to the target value.

```
# Function to check whether any pair exists  
# whose sum is equal to the given target value  
def two_sum(arr, target):  
    n = len(arr)
```

```
    # Iterate through each element in the array  
    for i in range(n):
```

```
        # For each element arr[i], check every  
        # other element arr[j] that comes after it  
        for j in range(i + 1, n):
```

```
            # Check if the sum of the current pair  
            # equals the target  
            if arr[i] + arr[j] == target:  
                return True
```

```
        # If no pair is found after checking  
        # all possibilities  
    return False
```

```
arr = [0, -1, 2, -3, 1]  
target = -2
```

```
# Call the two_sum function and print the result  
if two_sum(arr, target):  
    print("true")  
else:  
    print("false")
```

- 2) Two pointers: time complexity $O(n)$ and space is $O(1)$
The idea is to begin with two corners of the given array. We use two index variables left and right to traverse from both corners. Run a loop while $left < right$.

```
# Function to check whether any pair exists  
# whose sum is equal to the given target value  
def two_sum(arr, target):  
    # Sort the array
```

```
    left, right = 0, len(arr) - 1
```

```
    # Iterate while left pointer is less than right  
    while left < right:  
        sum = arr[left] + arr[right]
```

```
# Check if the sum matches the target
if sum == target:
    return True
elif sum < target:
    left += 1 # Move left pointer to the right
else:
    right -= 1 # Move right pointer to the left

# If no pair is found
return False

arr = [-3, -1, 0, 1, 2]
target = -2

# Call the two_sum function and print the result
if two_sum(arr, target):
    print("true")
else:
    print("false")
```